Data-Based Decision Making

The whole process on one page: check your data, find the mean and trend, make the call, pick a strategy.

Washoe County School District
Content: A. Forsyth, 2026

1 Is your data ready?

All four must be true before you make any decision.

1. **At least 6 data points across a 3-week period?**
   No → keep teaching and collecting
2. **At least 8 opportunities, trials, or steps in each data point?**
   No → keep teaching and collecting
3. **No break in the data longer than 4 school days in a row?**
   No → keep teaching and collecting
4. **Does the data truly represent the student? (No seizures, med changes, or similar events skewing performance.)**
   No → collect more representative data

Any "no": continue the learning plan and data collection, then check again. **All four "yes":** move to Part 2.

2 Find the mean and the trend

PHASE MEAN

1. Add the daily means (% correct or % independence).
2. Divide by the number of data points.
3. That total is your phase mean.

Example: 10 + 20 + 25 + 15 + 20 + 20 = 110 → 110 ÷ 6 = **18.3 = phase mean**

TREND LINE

1. Circle the first three and the last three data points.
2. In each circle, mark where mid-day and mid-level cross.*
3. Connect the two marks with a line. That is your trend.

*Mid-day: the middle day's data point, marked with a vertical line. Mid-level: a horizontal line through the middle value.

3 Name the trend, compare the means

Increasing / accelerating: the line rises from left to right.

Decreasing / decelerating: the line falls from left to right.

Flat: the line starts and ends at about the same point.

PHASE MEAN COMPARISON

1. Compare the previous phase mean to the current phase mean.
2. The difference tells you how much the student moved.

Example: October = 15%, November = 18% → a **3% increase** in phase means.

4 Decision time

Find your trend, then your mean, then act.

IF THE TREND IS	AND THE MEAN...	THEN...
Flat	was lower than the previous phase	Improve motivation
	stayed the same as the previous phase	Improve motivation, or simplify the skill and improve antecedents
	improved from the previous phase	No changes to make
Accelerating	stayed the same or was lower than the previous phase	Improve motivation
	improved from the previous phase	No changes to make
Decelerating	...and the goal or skill was academic	Improve motivation
	...and the goal was lowering a behavior occurrence	No changes to make
	...and the goal was increasing a replacement behavior	Revisit the behavior plan, FBA, and replacement behavior
Met mastery	the student met the mastery criteria	Extend the skill (counting 1-10 → 1-20), raise the criteria (60% → 80% independence), or change materials to increase generalization

5 Pick your strategy

Matched to the decision you just made in Part 4.

Improve antecedents

What happens before and around the response.

- Does the attention cue grab the student? If not, change it or try a different cue.
- Change how materials are presented: darker background, left-to-right or top-to-bottom, larger photo.
- Check symbolic understanding (run a symbol assessment).
- State the learning intention and expectations before instruction; simplify it to a few words.
- Increase or decrease the prompt delay/latency.
- Seat the student away from distractors, or use an alternative learning environment.
- Recheck the student's response mode and whether the setup still matches it.
- Use manipulatives that match the concept; use single-phrase buttons.

Improve motivation

Make the work worth doing.

- Conduct a new preference assessment.
- Use a stronger reinforcer.
- Restrict access to the highly preferred reinforcer so it stays powerful during instruction.
- Thicken the reinforcement schedule (every 2 answers → every answer).
- Offer choices: which skill first, where to work, which staff member to work with.
- Provide adaptive seating.
- Differentiate feedback for correct vs. incorrect responses (tone, language, reinforcement).

Remediation and skill simplification

Shrink the skill until success is possible.

- Focus on fewer targets for a cycle (1-10 → 1-5).
- Reduce the number of options in the array.
- Reduce the number of steps (getting dressed → pulling up pants).
- Reteach prerequisite skills.
- Use errorless learning: CTD, PTD, simultaneous prompting.
- Use paired stimulus: a matching visual stimulus throughout instruction.